

AI Pilot-to-Business-Case Checklist

Ten executive questions every AI use case should survive

Use this as a first-pass screen for one AI use case. The score matters less than the conversation the questions force.

Best used by an executive sponsor, business owner, or senior manager before an AI pilot moves from experiment to scale.

How to use it: pick one initiative, answer with evidence, and mark any answer that depends on confidence, optimism, or a future clean-up project.

Ownership

1. Which executive owns the outcome?

Not the pilot, not the tool, not the vendor relationship. The cost, risk, revenue, speed, quality, or customer outcome.

2. Which decision, approval, handoff, or customer-facing step changes if this works?

If the answer is “people will work faster,” the use case is not defined tightly enough.

Risk and governance

3. What could this AI use case get wrong, and who is accountable for catching it?

Name the failure mode, the control, and the person or team responsible.

4. What systems, data, approvals, or customer records can the AI see or influence?

Start with where the tool can read, write, recommend, or trigger action.

5. What human review remains mandatory?

Separate automation from delegated judgment. If everything is human in the loop, define the loop.

Use in real work

6. Whose daily routine has to change for the value to show up?

Name the team, the moment in the workflow, and what they must do differently.

7. What has to be true before more teams use it?

Look for access rules, manager expectations, training, and exception handling.

Evidence of value

8. What number would make the business say this was worth keeping?

Use one primary measure before adding supporting metrics.

9. What baseline are you comparing against?

Without a baseline, AI impact becomes a story instead of evidence.

10. What would cause you to stop, redesign, or not scale this use case?

A serious AI program defines stop conditions before the pilot has sponsors, spend, and internal pride attached to it.

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If these answers expose a gap between the pilot and the business case, book a 45-minute call with Clark to pressure-test one AI use case before it scales.